

Downsides of pornography

Pornography can be misused or misinterpreted, which can lead to an unhealthy relationship with sex in the real world.

"Porn sex" is often very different from "real sex": the people typically behave differently from regular people, and what they do is often very unusual, or even unpleasant and violent.

The sex or sexual acts portrayed in porn do not show sex as part of a healthy relationship. Instead, porn can lead people to think that they can treat those they have sex with as "sex objects."

Some people may feel disappointed by sex in the real world because it's not the same as sex portrayed in porn.

Female porn actors tend to have large breasts and no pubic hair, while males have large penises. This can damage people's body confidence, as most people don't look like this.

Some people become desensitized to the porn they watch and it no longer arouses them, or it desensitizes them to the pleasure of real sex.

Some people develop an unhealthy obsession with porn if they overuse it. Overwatching porn can be difficult to stop.

Pornography and the Internet

Tweens and teens are increasingly exposed to pornography online, and often before they have learned about sex or had sex themselves. They may seek out pornography intentionally, or stumble across it by accident if it appears unexpectedly on a website or in a search for educational material about sex. Such early exposure to sexually explicit images may be distressing, and is likely to leave teens misinformed about intimacy and sex as part of a healthy relationship. Young people may feel pressured to imitate activities they have seen online, or engage in risky sexual behaviors, such as not using a condom.



Online access

Parents can set age-appropriate restrictions on phones, tablets, and computers, too, and keep the family computer in a common area. Having a conversation is essential, too, as talking about porn will help teens to approach it responsibly.

Finding balance

If a teen is concerned about their own use of porn, or is unsure if it's healthy, then talking to a friend may be useful. Having open conversations about pornography can help a teen to establish limits for what's a healthy use of porn and what isn't.

GOOD TO KNOW

Talking about pornography

- Start by asking someone you trust what they think about pornography. This allows you both to contribute as much or as little as you want.
- Ask them to keep everything confidential, but don't be ashamed or make the person you are talking to feel ashamed, either.

When and where

Having a balanced approach to pornography includes restricting use to when and where it is appropriate.

